

Highlighting projects

COMPLETE LEARNING GUIDE

What You'll Learn

For students and freshers without much full-time work experience, the projects section often does the heaviest lifting on a resume — it's frequently the strongest evidence a recruiter has of actual applied skill, more concrete than a listed skill or a course grade. Yet many student resumes waste this section by listing a project title and a vague one-line description ('Built a machine learning project on housing prices') that gives a recruiter no real sense of scope, difficulty, or outcome. This sub-module covers how to choose which projects deserve resume space, how to structure a project entry so its technical depth and impact are both visible, and how to explicitly connect projects to the specific role being applied for rather than presenting a generic project list.

1. Choosing Which Projects to Include

Not every project belongs on a resume — the goal is 2-4 strong, relevant projects rather than an exhaustive list of every assignment ever completed, since a long undifferentiated list dilutes attention away from the strongest entries. Prioritize projects that are most relevant to the specific role (a web development role favors a full-stack project over an unrelated data-visualization one, even if the latter was academically graded higher), that involved genuine individual contribution (versus a group project where your specific role is unclear), and that have a demonstrable, describable outcome rather than just 'it worked.'

2. Structuring a Project Entry

A strong project entry has three visible components: a clear title (what it is, in plain language), the specific tech stack or tools used, and 2-3 bullet points covering what was built, key technical decisions, and the outcome or result. Avoid a single dense paragraph — bulleted, scannable entries let a recruiter absorb the key facts in seconds, which matters because resumes are typically skimmed in well under a minute on a first pass.

- Entry structure: 'Project Title | Tech Stack (Month Year – Month Year)' followed by 2-3 bullets: what problem it solved, a key technical decision, and the measurable outcome.

3. Writing Action-Oriented Project Bullets

Each bullet should start with a strong action verb (Built, Designed, Implemented, Optimized, Deployed) and describe what was actually done and why, not just what the project was about in the abstract. A bullet like 'Project on customer churn prediction' describes a topic, not an accomplishment; 'Built a churn-prediction model using logistic regression and engineered features from transaction history, improving prediction accuracy from a 62% baseline to 81%' describes an accomplishment with a visible technical decision and a measured result.

- Weak: 'Machine learning project to predict customer churn.'
- Strong: 'Built a churn-prediction pipeline in Python using logistic regression and feature engineering on transaction history, improving accuracy from a 62% baseline to 81% on held-out test data.'

4. Connecting Projects to the Target Role

The same project can be described in slightly different ways depending on the role being applied for, emphasizing the aspects most relevant to that specific job — this is not dishonest, since the project genuinely had multiple facets, and highlighting the relevant one is simply good targeting. A single e-commerce recommendation project might emphasize the machine learning model when applying for a data science role, but emphasize the API design and deployment when applying for a backend engineering role, since both are genuinely part of the same project.

- For a data science role: 'Designed a collaborative-filtering recommendation model, improving click-through rate by 18% in a simulated A/B test.'
- For a backend role (same underlying project): 'Built and deployed a REST API serving the recommendation model, handling concurrent requests with sub-200ms average latency.'

5. Including Links: GitHub, Live Demos, and Documentation

A link to a working GitHub repository or a live demo substantially strengthens a project entry by letting a recruiter or interviewer verify the work directly rather than taking the resume's description on faith — this matters especially for technical roles where interviewers often browse a candidate's linked repository before or during the interview. When including a GitHub link, the repository itself should have a clear README (what the project does, how to run it, key decisions) since an unexplained code dump undermines the credibility a link is meant to build.

- Before including a GitHub link, check that the repository has: a README with a short description, clear setup instructions, and no leftover placeholder/test commits with unprofessional messages.

6. Academic vs. Personal vs. Internship Projects

These three project types read slightly differently to a recruiter and are worth labeling implicitly through context: academic/coursework projects show applied theoretical understanding but sometimes lack real-world constraints; personal/side projects show initiative and self-direction, which many recruiters weight heavily as a signal of genuine interest beyond coursework; internship projects carry the most weight because they involved real stakes and likely real users or data, but must be described carefully to avoid disclosing confidential company details.

For an internship project, describing the problem and your contribution in general terms (without company-confidential specifics) is standard and expected.

7. Before/After: A Full Project Entry Rewrite

Seeing a full entry rewritten end to end makes the cumulative effect of these principles clearest — vague description becomes a scoped, technical, outcome-driven entry.

- Before: 'Made a website for a college event using HTML, CSS, and JavaScript. It had a registration form and worked well.'
- After: 'Event Registration Platform | HTML, CSS, JavaScript, Firebase (Feb 2025) — Built a responsive registration site for a 500+ attendee college fest, including real-time seat-availability tracking via Firebase; reduced manual registration processing time from ~2 hours to near-instant, with zero double-bookings across the event.'

Common Pitfalls

- Listing every project ever completed instead of 2-4 strong, relevant ones, diluting attention from the best entries.
- Writing a single vague sentence per project instead of scannable, specific bullets.
- Describing what a project was about instead of what was specifically built, decided, and achieved.
- Presenting the exact same project description regardless of which role is being applied for.
- Including a GitHub link to a repository with no README or unclear setup instructions.
- Disclosing confidential company details when describing an internship project.
- Omitting any measurable outcome, leaving even a well-built project sounding purely descriptive.

Key Takeaways

- Include 2-4 strong, relevant projects rather than an exhaustive list of every assignment completed.
- Structure each entry with a title, tech stack, and 2-3 outcome-focused bullets, not a dense paragraph.
- Start bullets with action verbs and describe specific decisions and results, not just the general topic.
- The same project can be honestly re-emphasized for different roles by highlighting its most relevant facet.
- A linked GitHub repo strengthens credibility only if it has a clear README and clean commit history.
- Internship projects carry real-world weight but should describe contribution without confidential specifics.

Learn More

Indeed — How to List Projects on a Resume

<https://www.indeed.com/career-advice/resumes-cover-letters/how-to-list-projects-on-resume>

Harvard Business Review — How to Write a Resume That Stands Out

<https://hbr.org/2019/01/how-to-write-a-resume-that-stands-out>

GitHub Docs — About READMEs

<https://docs.github.com/en/repositories/managing-your-repositorys-settings-and-features/customizing-your-repository/about-readmes>